

**Concession and Succession:
Where Escalation Buys Removal at the Price of an
Accountable Successor**

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Abstract

Two findings about campaigns against entrenched rulers have been established separately. Nonviolent campaigns remove incumbents more often than armed campaigns, and escalation reduces the participation on which removal depends. Armed revolutions that succeed, however, are less often reversed, while sustained unarmed mobilisation is associated with successor regimes that are more durable and more accountable. Escalation is therefore evaluated against different outcomes in different literatures. We combine the outcomes in a stipulated model. Attention raises the ruler's cost of both waiting and repression, so it moves cases out of delay in both directions: 610 waiting cases of the incumbent's decision problem move to repression and 400 to concession. Attention enlarges the region in which concession is cheapest from 0.158 to 0.286 of the swept region, and escalation then reduces it to 0.102. Repression that removes civilian organisations faster than armed ones shifts a campaign's composition without conversion or recruitment; the two wings reach parity after 6.24 periods of maximal repression, when 0.025 of the original campaign remains. Escalation raises the probability of removal only where an intact civilian campaign could withdraw at most 0.0478 of the coercive apparatus's cooperation. Under the condition most favourable to escalation, it raises the probability of removal from 0.107 to 0.184 and retains 0.109 of the probability of an accountable successor that not escalating would secure. Across 600 random parameter draws, escalation raised the probability of removal in 62 and lowered the probability of an accountable successor in all 62.

Introduction

An original dataset of major resistance campaigns between 1900 and 2006 showed that nonviolent campaigns achieved maximalist objectives more often than armed ones, and attributed the difference to broader participation and to loyalty shifts among the opponent's security forces, whereas armed campaigns mobilised fewer people and gave the opponent a justification for violent counterattack (Stephan and Chenoweth 2008). Contemporaneous armed struggle does not improve the outcomes of unarmed campaigns and is negatively associated with participation and thereby with success (Chenoweth and Schock 2015). Security-force defection strongly influences the outcome of nonviolent uprisings, and troops who receive benefits from the regime, or who believe that it can survive, do not defect (Nepstad 2013). An agent-based model reaches a similar conclusion by a different method, finding that targeting the regime's pillars of support produces more defections than rapid mass recruitment, even for small campaigns (Chenoweth et al. 2022).

A second literature concerns what follows removal. Of the 280 autocratic regimes in existence between 1946 and 2010, transitions from one autocracy to another account for about half of all regime changes (Geddes et al. 2014), and many of the resulting regimes are hybrids (Levitsky and Way 2010). Removal is therefore a precondition for two further outcomes, the survival of the successor and its accountability, and these can fail independently. For accountability the evidence favours mobilisation: across 112 young democracies in 80 countries, democracies that emerged from mass mobilisation survived longer, and sustained unarmed uprisings produced the longest-lasting ones, because such campaigns build organisations that supply a leadership cadre, link gov-

ernment to society and constrain the post-transition government (Kadivar 2018). For survival the evidence points the other way: violent revolutions are less likely to be reversed because they produce regimes with strong and loyal armies, and violence lowers the likelihood of counterrevolutionary success without lowering the likelihood of counterrevolutionary emergence (Clarke 2022).

Each of these findings holds the other outcome fixed, and neither addresses what happens to removal, survival and accountability together when a single decision changes. Movements are coalitions of factions, and escalation is more likely when a movement contains violence-wielding factions and nonviolent tactics are failing (Ryckman 2019). Escalation is therefore most likely under the conditions in which, as shown below, it does the most damage to accountability.

We combine the three outcomes in a model whose functional forms are stipulated and stated in full. Nothing is fitted to any campaign, no probability estimates a real probability, and no country is represented. Three grids are swept exhaustively, a robustness test uses a seeded random ensemble, and a set of invariants is checked on every run.

The incumbent's decision

In each period a ruler facing a campaign can concede, repress or wait, and the model compares these options by their cost to the ruler. The standard formal treatment of the choice between concession and repression under the threat of revolution is due to Acemoglu and Robinson (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006). The model here adds waiting as a third option, makes the cost of repression depend on the coercive apparatus, and follows the consequences of the choice through to the successor regime.

Conceding costs a base amount plus a term that increases with the campaign's escalation, because a ruler who expects to be killed or tried after leaving office values staying more highly. This term follows the finding that leaders concede more readily when the consequences of losing office are less severe (Debs and Goemans 2010). Repressing costs a base amount divided by the cooperation the coercive apparatus still extends, plus terms for outside attention and for the material leverage the campaign has withdrawn. Division by cooperation makes force cheap while the apparatus cooperates and expensive as it stops, following work that treats authoritarian rule as a bargain with subordinates who can withdraw (Svolik 2012; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003). Waiting costs a base amount plus terms for leverage and attention, since disruption makes delay costly.

The campaign is described by two parameters. Leverage is the fraction of material cooperation it has withdrawn through strikes, boycotts and non-payment. Attention is the visibility of the confrontation to parties whose reactions the ruler must take into account. The decision is computed over a grid of 4896 cells spanning institutional cooperation and leverage.

Raising attention from low to high increases the cost of both waiting and repression, and therefore moves cases out of waiting in both directions. Of the cells in which a low-attention ruler would wait, 610 move to repression and 400 to concession, a ratio of 1.525. Whether greater visibility leads to concession or to repression depends on the cell. The empirical literature makes a related point:

dissent and repression are endogenous, and where a government represses preventively, observed dissent does not predict responsive repression (Ritter and Conrad 2016).

Overall, attention enlarges the region in which concession is cheapest, from 0.158 of the swept region at low attention to 0.286 at high attention. Escalation then reduces it to 0.102, a loss of 0.183 that exceeds the gain from attention. A campaign that becomes visible and then escalates therefore faces fewer conditions under which concession is the ruler's cheapest option than a campaign that does neither.

The boundary of the concession region has a closed form. Repression stops being cheapest when institutional cooperation falls below $\beta_r/(\kappa - \alpha_a a - \alpha_\ell \ell)$, where κ is the cost of conceding, a attention and ℓ leverage. With attention high, cooperation must fall to 0.280 before concession is cheapest against a campaign with no material leverage, and to 0.526 against a campaign that has withdrawn all of it. Leverage therefore nearly doubles the level of institutional cooperation at which a ruler still finds concession cheapest. The simulated boundary matches the closed form at every level of leverage to within one grid step. With no leverage and no attention, no cell concedes and the ruler waits.

Differential attrition under repression

Civilian organisations depend on assembly, publicity, open membership and public identification, and clandestine armed organisations depend on these less. If the two wings of a campaign have different retention rates under repression, with the civilian wing more sensitive, the composition of the surviving campaign changes without any decision by its members.

The odds between the wings after t periods are $\frac{w_t}{1-w_t} = \frac{w_0}{1-w_0} \left(\frac{s_A}{s_C} \right)^t$, where s_A and s_C are the retention rates of the armed and civilian wings. The expression was checked against period-by-period iteration; the invariant requires agreement to within 10^{-9} , and the observed discrepancy is at the level of double-precision rounding.

A campaign that begins with 0.1 of its capacity in an armed wing reaches parity between the wings after 6.24 periods of maximal repression, when 0.025 of the original campaign remains. After six periods of maximal repression the armed share is 0.479 and total capacity is 0.029; after six periods without repression the armed share is 0.119, close to its starting value. No member converts or is recruited in this calculation.

The shift depends only on the difference between the two sensitivities. When they are set equal, so that repression affects both wings alike, the armed share after six periods is 0.1, its starting value. The change in composition therefore reflects how selectively repression acts. This is consistent with evidence that different repressive instruments serve different purposes: political terror suppresses organised threats, restrictions on civil liberties deter collective action, and the two have different effects on how a dictator eventually leaves office (Escribà-Folch 2013).

Figure 1c shows why the attrition and decision mechanisms have to be analysed together. As repression increases, the armed share of the campaign rises while the campaign as a whole shrinks.

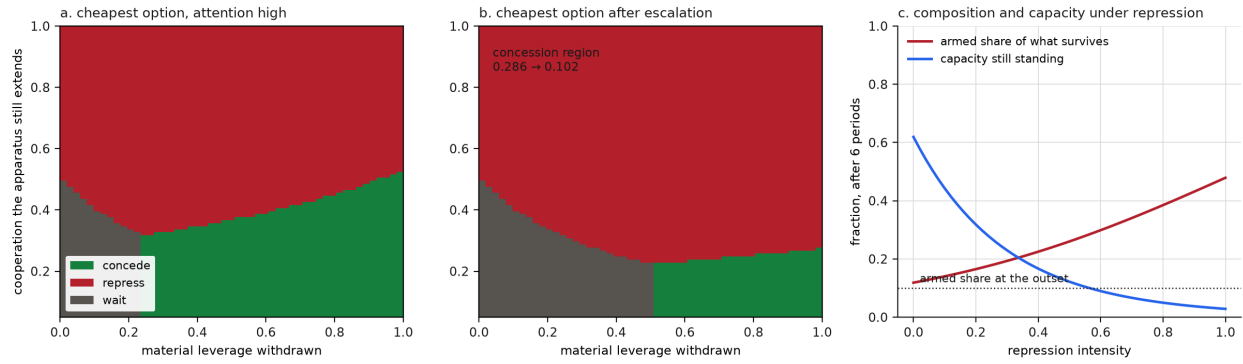


Figure 1: The incumbent's decision and the attrition of the campaign. (a) The ruler's cheapest option across institutional cooperation and withdrawn leverage, with attention high. (b) The same map after the campaign escalates; the concession region contracts from 0.286 to 0.102 of the swept region. (c) The armed share of surviving capacity and the total surviving capacity after six periods, as a function of repression intensity.

An analysis of the first curve alone would conclude that repression radicalises campaigns, and an analysis of the second alone that it destroys them. Both effects occur together, and escalation determines where on both curves a campaign ends up.

Removal, durability and accountability

In the model, escalation means two things at once: the campaign shifts its own composition toward an armed wing, and that shift draws heavier repression. Escalation can help. An armed wing can remove an incumbent by force without waiting for the apparatus to defect, and the model includes that channel: the probability of removal depends both on withdrawn cooperation and on the armed wing's capacity relative to the regime's remaining coercive strength.

The three outcomes are scored separately. Removal is the departure of the incumbent. Durability is the survival of the successor regime and increases with the armed capacity it inherits, the mechanism identified by Clarke. Accountability increases with the civilian capacity that survives and decreases with the armed share of what remains, the mechanism identified by Kadivar. The model does not constrain the three outcomes to peak at the same level of escalation.

The institutional setting is summarised by one quantity, the share of the apparatus's cooperation that an intact civilian campaign could withdraw. An apparatus from which a civilian campaign can withdraw much cooperation is responsive to domestic noncooperation, and one from which it can withdraw little is insulated, for example by coup-proofing, foreign patronage, ethnic stacking or indifference. Sweeping this quantity against escalation identifies the conditions under which escalation improves the probability of removal.

Escalation raises the probability of removal only where an intact civilian campaign could withdraw at most 0.0478 of the apparatus's cooperation, which is 0.080 of the swept range. Elsewhere the civilian route to removal is more effective, and escalation lowers all three outcomes. This re-

produces the empirical finding that escalation is generally counterproductive and identifies the narrow set of conditions in which it is not.

Within those conditions the three outcomes diverge. We report them at the setting where escalation produces the largest gain in the probability of removal, which is the setting most favourable to escalation. There, escalation raises the probability of removal from 0.107 to 0.184, a gain of 0.078. Removal peaks at an escalation level of 0.61. Durability also peaks at 0.61, since the successor regime that escalation produces is more likely to survive, in line with Clarke's mechanism. Accountability peaks at 0. Escalating to the level that maximises removal retains 0.109 of the probability of an accountable successor that not escalating would have secured.

Over 0.61 of the escalation range, the probability of removal rises while the probability of removal followed by an accountable successor falls, and over the same range durability rises while accountability falls. Claims that escalation works and claims that it does not can therefore both be correct about the same case, because they refer to different outcomes.

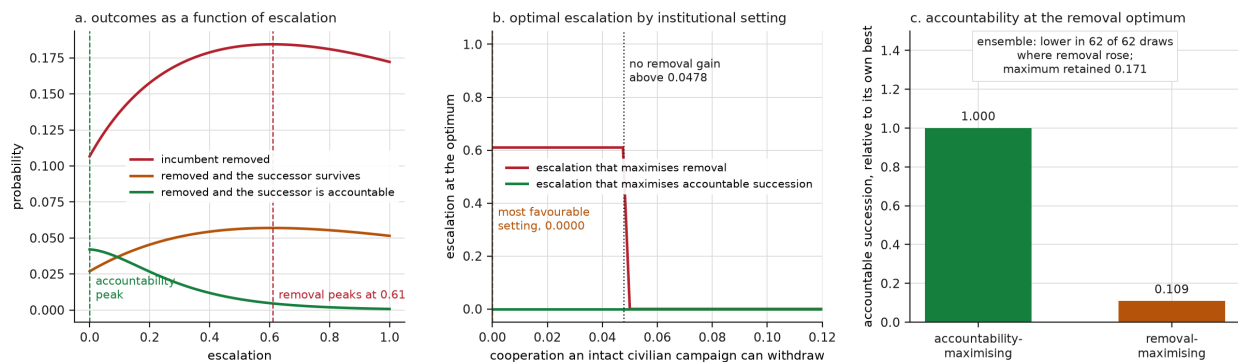


Figure 2: Removal, durability and accountability under escalation. (a) The three outcomes at the institutional setting where escalation produces the largest gain in the probability of removal; removal and durability peak at escalation 0.61 and accountability at 0. (b) The escalation level that maximises each outcome, as a function of how much cooperation an intact civilian campaign could withdraw; escalation stops raising the probability of removal above 0.0478. (c) The probability of an accountable successor under the removal-maximising choice, relative to the accountability-maximising choice.

Robustness of the divergence

Because the model has about a dozen stipulated constants, the divergence was tested with an ensemble. Each constant was multiplied by an independent uniform factor between 0.6 and 1.4, the institutional setting was drawn at random, and the analysis was repeated. In 600 draws, escalation raised the probability of removal in 62. In all 62 it lowered the probability of an accountable successor. The best case in the ensemble retained 0.171 of the accountability that not escalating would have secured, and the median retained 0.066. Where escalation helped, the median gain in the probability of removal was 0.050.

Relation to radical-flank effects

The strongest evidence against this conclusion comes from experiments on radical flanks. In two experiments with 2,772 participants, the presence of a radical flank increased support for a moderate faction of the same movement; the effect was driven by radical tactics such as property destruction or violence, and its mechanism was contrast, with the moderate faction appearing less radical (Simpson et al. 2022). The positive radical-flank hypothesis was first proposed in work on the funding of civil rights organisations (Haines 1984). The model does not contradict this finding, because it concerns a different quantity. Third-party support for a faction is distinct from the campaign's organisational capacity and from the character of the successor regime. The model concerns the capacity that remains after repression acts selectively on the campaign, and what that capacity can build. A flank effect that raises public sympathy while differential attrition destroys the civilian organisation would produce the pattern computed here.

A second objection is that a campaign in the narrow set of conditions may have no better option. If the apparatus cannot be moved by civilian noncooperation, the civilian route to removal is closed, and retaining 0.109 of the probability of an accountable successor may be the best outcome available. The model does not dispute this. It quantifies a trade-off without recommending a choice, and it shows that the trade-off is large and that the conditions under which escalation helps removal are those under which it costs the most accountability. A higher probability of removal does not by itself imply a better outcome.

Limitations

The functional forms are stipulated: exponential retention, a multiplicative accountability term, an additive cost structure for the incumbent's decision and a hazard form for removal. They were chosen for transparency, and none was estimated. The ensemble tests robustness to the constants but not to the functional forms.

Two known mechanisms are absent. Repression can backfire and increase mobilisation: whether repression of unarmed protest backfires depends on pre-existing campaign infrastructure and parallel media, which raise both domestic mobilisation and security defections after violent repression (Sutton et al. 2014; Hess and Martin 2006), and exposure to a regime's past repression can increase later participation (Lawrence 2016). Including backfire would raise the returns to remaining unarmed and strengthen the conclusion, so the results reported here are conservative in this respect. The model also omits concession from strength, in which a ruling party accepts democratisation because it expects to keep winning elections (Slater and Wong 2013); the incumbent here concedes only when concession is the cheapest of three options.

The difference in sensitivity to repression between clandestine and open organisations drives the attrition results, and we found no empirical estimate of it. We stipulate two values and report the case in which they are equal and the composition does not change. The direction of the effect follows from the organisational argument, and its size depends on a parameter that has not been measured.

The model treats three further things as given. It assumes the ruler can observe the apparatus's cooperation, although under preference falsification an apparatus can appear cooperative until it abruptly stops (Kuran 1991). It does not model what an armed wing becomes, which depends on how it recruits and on the resources available to it (Weinstein 2006), or whether a fragmented movement can maintain nonviolent discipline (Pearlman 2011). And it takes the existence of the campaign as given, although the conditions that produce major nonviolent campaigns are themselves a subject of research (Butcher and Svensson 2014; Chenoweth 2020).

The model represents no particular country, campaign or ruler, and its probabilities are properties of stipulated functions. No parameter was estimated from campaign-level data such as NAVCO (Chenoweth and Shay 2022) or event-level data such as ACLED (Raleigh et al. 2010), and in its current form the model makes no prediction that those data could test. It is not advice: a decision about escalation concerns a particular apparatus, particular factions and particular consequences, none of which the model contains. Its results are structural. Removal, durability and accountability are distinct outcomes, a single decision can move them in different directions, and the conditions under which escalation makes removal more likely are those under which it most reduces the likelihood of an accountable successor.

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